

Math Education Digital Shadows for Investigating Learning with GenAI: Mathematics Performance, Anxiety, and Confidence in LLMs

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ABSTRACT

Understanding the impact of large language models (LLMs) on mathematics education requires data on LLMs' mathematical performance and biases. To this end, we introduce Math Education Digital Shadows (MEDS), a dataset mapping how LLMs reason about mathematics across human- and AI-like personifications. MEDS comprises 28,000 runs from 14 LLMs (i.e., Mistral, Qwen, DeepSeek, IBM Granite, Microsoft Phi, and xAI Grok) generated under human-shadow and AI-assistant conditions. Each record (digital shadow) includes a set of prompts; psychological and sociodemographic metadata; and four mathematics tasks: (i) interviews about relationships with mathematics, (ii) three psychometric questionnaires on mathematics self-efficacy and anxiety, (iii) one cognitive network capturing attitudes towards mathematics, and (iv) 18 high-school mathematics quiz items enriched with reasoning explanations and confidence scores. Analyses of the data show that LLMs exhibit differences in attitudes and performance across human-shadow and AI-assistant modes, including human-like negative attitudes towards mathematics, logical fallacies, and overconfidence in mathematics. As a data resource, MEDS can benefit learning scientists and developers of safer AI tutors in mathematics.

Generative AI (GenAI) is making its way into mathematics education during a period of genuine pedagogical challenge^{1,2}. The advent of large language models (LLMs) has given students around-the-clock access to expert-level systems³, potentially broadening access to personalised educational content^{4,5} while also heightening the risk of exposure to biased or fallacious educational material^{2,6-8} or undermining students' self-efficacy⁵. Recent LLM-auditing work on DeepSeek⁸ shows why prompt-conditioned datasets should be used to compare model outputs across controlled conditions, especially when final answers may differ from intermediate reasoning or suppress specific information. This risk must be considered alongside GenAI's usage statistics. In the 2025 EU-wide Eurostat module on GenAI, including ChatGPT, Copilot, Gemini, and LLaMA, 9.4% of people aged 16–74 reported using such tools for formal education^{9,10}. Among individuals aged 16–24, educational usage rose to 39.3%, indicating that AI-assisted education is already a substantial practice among younger learners in Europe¹¹. This rapid adoption is also due to the speed at which LLMs are evolving^{2,12}. Originally conceived as models for generating⁶ or summarising language¹³, LLMs are increasingly becoming agentic^{8,14,15}, i.e., capable of making decisions or giving feedback under uncertainty.

The evolution of LLMs towards agentic capabilities has also included significant improvements in mathematical problem solving. Whereas older models such as GPT-3 achieved very low scores (14%) on high-school-level mathematics items (cf. MathBench¹⁶), more recent models such as GPT-4o achieved scores almost four times as high. Similar improvements in mathematical reasoning were also observed on other mathematics benchmarks¹⁷⁻¹⁹. Consequently, mathematics education is benefiting considerably from LLMs' improved feedback skills³. Recent human-centred studies indicate that mathematics

students rely on LLMs to elucidate problem-solving algorithms²⁰, evaluate solutions^{4,21}, and minimise the effort required to tackle challenging problems^{3,5}. Conversely, institutions are slowly embracing LLMs as mathematics tutors, e.g., GenAI assistants primarily devoted to supporting students’ mathematics learning and problem solving^{1,22}. This slow adoption rate is also due to a lack of clear evidence about the cognitive repercussions of using LLMs in mathematics education^{19,21}. This is a significant gap because mathematics entails not only linguistic and mathematical knowledge but also several human skills, such as confidence³, anxiety management²³, self-efficacy²⁴, and resilience to failure²⁵. Therefore, allowing students to interact with potential LLM-based mathematics tutors raises a key research question (RQ):

RQ: Can LLMs convey mathematical knowledge effectively without expressing mathematics anxiety or conveying disruptive mathematical biases to users, even across a wide variety of prompting conditions?

To address this RQ, we introduce the Math Education Digital Shadows (MEDS) dataset as a reusable, multimodal, LLM-based resource. Exploring LLMs’ mathematics performance and attitudes requires a representation that preserves not only problem-solving answers but also the contextual framings under which those answers appear, e.g., whether an LLM introduces stereotypical perceptions such as “math is boring” in its responses²⁶. Digital shadowing²⁷ offers a convenient way to achieve that representation. While digital twins are characterised by a bidirectional data flow with their physical counterparts, digital shadows are more parsimonious^{28,29}: digital shadows record what a system does across controlled conditions without updating, simulating, or influencing external counterparts^{30–32}. To address this gap, we present MEDS as a digital-shadow resource that facilitates the study of how LLMs engage with mathematics under psychologically and educationally grounded conditions.

MEDS goes beyond mathematical performance by adding data on LLMs’ confidence, anxiety, semantic associations, and reflective discourse about mathematics, AI tutoring, and STEM. We define a Math Education Digital Shadow as a structured record of an LLM’s mathematics-related psychological profile and problem-solving behaviour generated under specified constraints (four tasks, prompting mode, and persona profile). Throughout this resource, we use the term **human shadow** to denote an LLM instance prompted to simulate a synthetic individual defined by sociodemographic and psychological attributes (as opposed to an AI assistant, in which the model responds as itself). The term persona is reserved strictly for the underlying JSON attribute dictionary that defines a human shadow, not for the simulated entity itself. The accompanying dataset documentation describes personas through sociodemographic features³³ (e.g., age, gender, sexual orientation, city of residence, employment status, education level, and parental education) and psychological attributes (e.g., Big Five personality traits³⁴, favourite subjects³⁵, and psychometric scores³⁶). This structure makes latent human variables explicit and experimentally manipulable within LLMs. MEDS includes four complementary tasks used in relevant previous STEM-education studies: (i) qualitative responses about mathematics and mathematical thinking, inspired by previous research on LLMs’ affective biases³⁷; (ii) psychometric ratings with textual justifications^{23–25}; (iii) semantic associations with valence labels^{26,38}; and (iv) mathematical problem solving with reasoning and confidence scores³⁹.

Importantly, MEDS’ design treats mathematical behaviour as multidimensional, aligning with recent perspectives on AI and mathematics learning³. In the first task, the LLM-based digital shadow is asked about its relationship with mathematics, mathematics anxiety, prior use of AI for learning, and selected mathematical procedures. In the second task, the LLM completes the Mathematics Self-Efficacy Scale (MSES)²⁴, the Abbreviated Math Anxiety Scale (AMAS)²³, and the Mathematics Self-Efficacy and Anxiety Questionnaire (MSEAQ)²⁵, and provides both ratings and short linguistic explanations. In the third task, the LLM shadow produces a behavioural forma mentis network (BFMN) previously used to study negative perceptions of mathematics and anxiety^{26,35,38}. In the fourth task, the LLM shadow solves multiple-choice mathematics problems drawn from psychometric measures and covering high-school mathematics³⁹, while reporting both reasoning and confidence. MEDS therefore supports analyses that connect performance to self-efficacy, anxiety, and semantic framing rather than isolating correctness from the rest of educational cognition. For an overview of MEDS, see Fig. 1.

This resource adheres to the following scope and structure. The Results section demonstrates the internal consistency, completeness, and research potential of each component of MEDS, illustrating the types of scientific investigations that the



Figure 1. Overview of the MEDS prompting framework and response structure, showing the two modes (human shadows and AI assistants) and the four sequential tasks, together with example questions, scale items, and cue words used to generate each digital shadow. The label “MAES” in call 2 refers to the MSES scale. The mode field indicates human shadows ("human") or AI assistants ("llm"), even though all entries in MEDS were generated by LLMs.

dataset enables. The Methods section provides reproducibility instructions covering three main components: data generation, data processing, and data records. The data-generation pipeline is outlined in the *Data generation* subsection, including the prompt design adopted to define each personification mode, which is detailed under *Prompt building*. The processing steps applied to the data, including data cleaning, are described in the *Data processing* subsection. Data cleaning was one of the most critical phases of the entire pipeline, given the variability of the data produced by different LLMs. Finally, the structure of the resulting records is described in the *Data records* subsection. The role instructions for each personification mode are reported

therein, and the full text of the questions, scale items, cue words, and problems used as input for each task is provided in the Supplementary Information.

MEDS makes the following contribution: it is an observational resource for analysing GenAI’s prompt-conditioned behaviour in complex mathematical settings. This resource is not a proxy for human opinion. Comprising 28,000 LLM-generated runs, MEDS can simultaneously account for GenAI’s mathematics performance, confidence, anxiety, and attitudes. MEDS is designed as a reusable resource for research at the intersection of cognitive science^{38,40}, educational data science^{3,4}, explainable AI²⁶, and digital shadowing^{27,32}. MEDS’ prompting framework and behavioural, psychometric, and linguistic data will enable researchers to understand how LLMs may shape educational practice when used as tutors, assistants, or human-like mediators of mathematical knowledge in future LLM platforms.

Results

Since MEDS is intended as a reusable multidimensional resource rather than a conventional benchmark, the results in this article demonstrate the integrity, consistency, and research utility of each dataset component. The current section is therefore organised according to the same four tasks that structure MEDS, showing how each task captures and examines a complementary dimension of mathematical reasoning in large language models. Accordingly, the four result analyses are organised as follows.

- **Task 1:** identifies the qualitative reasoning component of MEDS by analysing the attitudes towards mathematics expressed by human shadows primed to love or hate mathematics and by AI assistants^{26,41}. In addition, it investigates the logical fallacies that emerge when LLMs are asked to provide mathematical explanations⁴².
- **Task 2:** characterises the psychometric component by comparing the distributions of MSES, AMAS, and MSEAQ scores^{23–25} between human-shadow and AI-assistant settings, assessing whether psychologically grounded prompting produces coherent and distinguishable psychometric profiles³³.
- **Task 3:** identifies the semantic component, first by evaluating the completeness and internal consistency of behavioural forma mentis networks^{26,38}. Second, it uses these networks to compare how different LLM families, including censored and uncensored variants, semantically and emotionally frame mathematics relative to science. These analyses show how semantic associations and emotional valence can reveal cognitive biases in mathematical attitudes, complementing the psychometric and linguistic dimensions of MEDS.
- **Task 4:** highlights the mathematical-performance component by jointly analysing mathematical accuracy and self-reported confidence, identifying family-specific calibration patterns and harmful overconfidence biases across LLMs⁴³.

Task 1: Relationships with Mathematics

This section combines two complementary perspectives on how language models relate to mathematics. As reported in Supplementary Information A.1 and Fig. 1, these questions concern each digital shadow’s relationship with mathematics and its mathematical explanations. We measured emotional tone with VADER⁴⁴ in responses to Q1, Q2, Q3, and Q7 about one’s personal relationship with mathematics. We evaluated fallacies⁴² in responses to Q4, Q5, and Q6, which required step-by-step technical explanations. See the *Methods for Task 1: sentiment analysis* and *Methods for Task 1: logical fallacy analysis* paragraphs for details on how VADER scores and fallacy categories are computed. Fig. 2b shows that emotional tone is influenced by priming. Scores are always positive under the “Math Lover” condition. Mistral Small 4 and Mistral Small 3.2 achieve the highest scores, while Granite 4 Tiny achieves the lowest. Conversely, under the “Math Hater” condition, the trend reverses. Grok 4.1 Fast and Magistral Small receive negative scores. Other models remain moderately positive even under this human-shadow condition, showing irregular resistance to the affective framing imposed on the human shadow. The neutral “LLM” condition lies between the higher- and lower-sentiment extremes. This implies a slight overall inclination towards positive sentiment about mathematics.

At the 85th percentile, the fallacy-of-logic category has the highest confidence threshold among all categories (0.56 for human-shadow mode and 0.58 for AI-assistant mode); see Methods for how this threshold is computed. This means only that

the classifier assigns this category a higher average confidence score, not that it is the most common fallacy in the dataset. Looking instead at the actual detection rates shown in Fig. 2a, the dominant fallacy shifts from family to family.

Granite 4 Tiny, Ministral 14B, and Anita 24B show a marked reliance on circular reasoning in AI-assistant mode. Mistral Small 3.2 and Mistral Small 4, by contrast, are dominated by the fallacy-of-logic category, but only in human-shadow mode. Grok 4.1 Fast and Qwen3.5 9B show high rates of the fallacy-of-relevance category in AI-assistant mode, particularly Grok. DeepSeek Chat shows the appeal-to-emotion category as dominant in both conditions. Granite 4 Tiny, Phi-4, and Ministral 3B remain the models with the highest no-fallacy rates.

Persona conditioning affects both emotional tone and argumentative style, with a greater impact on the former than on the latter and substantial variation across model families.

Task 2: Mathematics Anxiety and Self-Efficacy

Fig. 3 illustrates the distributions of summed scores for each run across the three psychometric scales. Reverse-valence items on the MSEAQ were rescored using a dedicated mapping, thereby preserving the integrity of the scale. Details of the reverse-valence items and the mapping used for conversion are available in Supplementary Information A.2.

The distributions are explicitly partitioned into human-shadow and AI-assistant data to highlight the primary behavioural disparities between the two prompting modes. The human-shadow distributions display considerable variance across all three scales, indicating that human-shadow conditioning successfully generated a broad spectrum of simulated educational cognition and varied psychological attitudes towards mathematics. This provides evidence that the prompting strategy generated diverse responses across human shadows when human-shadow mode was specified, in line with previous human–LLM studies^{37,45,46}.

As predicted, the variance among AI-assistant responses is negligible. Several language models provided identical responses and scores under the AI-assistant instructions, including Anita 24B (Uncensored), Ministral 14B (Reasoning), Ministral 3B, Phi-4 (Reasoning+), and Qwen3 4B (Thinking). Because the measures generated by these models showed no variance, their distributions could not be plotted. The comparison shows that, whereas AI-assistant output patterns are relatively uniform, psychologically grounded prompts can generate substantial variance. This finding confirms our expectation that LLMs can shadow variability in psychometric responses³⁶ and aligns with previous studies using LLMs as limited human shadows for psychometric surveys^{36,37}.

Beyond the strong contrasts in statistical variance, the psychometric distributions reveal a distinct directional skew in how AI-assistant models self-report their mathematics anxiety (AMAS²³; MSEAQ²⁵) and mathematics self-efficacy (MSES²⁴; MSEAQ²⁵). Under standard AI-assistant instructions, the models consistently project a highly confident, low-anxiety profile. This divergence is particularly evident in the MSES distributions, where the AI-assistant peaks are markedly shifted to the right relative to the human-shadow data, indicating systematically higher self-efficacy. Concurrently, their AMAS distributions tend to cluster towards the lower bounds of the scale, largely avoiding the high-anxiety tails that characterise the human-shadow data. On the MSEAQ self-efficacy subscale, the AI-assistant baselines exhibit a pronounced rightward skew towards the upper end of the scale. By contrast, the MSEAQ anxiety subscale shows a reciprocal leftward skew: the AI-assistant baselines are lower and largely exclude the high-anxiety tails seen in the human-shadow data. Together, these directional shifts suggest that, unless specifically prompted otherwise, some LLMs tend to report artificially inflated mathematical competence, as also suggested by recent studies^{3,21}.

The distinct distributional characteristics observed in the AI-assistant data—specifically, the systematic rightward shift in self-efficacy on the MSES and the stark inter-model disagreement regarding baseline anxiety on the AMAS—highlight why the dataset is explicitly positioned as an observational resource for GenAI bias rather than a proxy for authentic human opinion.

Task 3: Semantic and Emotional Associations with Mathematics

This section presents the results for Task 3 by analysing the semantic associations and emotional evaluations for a set of 50 cue words, reported in Fig. 1 and Supplementary Information A.3. Following previous cognitive-science studies^{38,40}, the cue words in MEDS include mathematical notions (e.g., problem-solving and numbers), classroom experiences (e.g., teacher and failure),

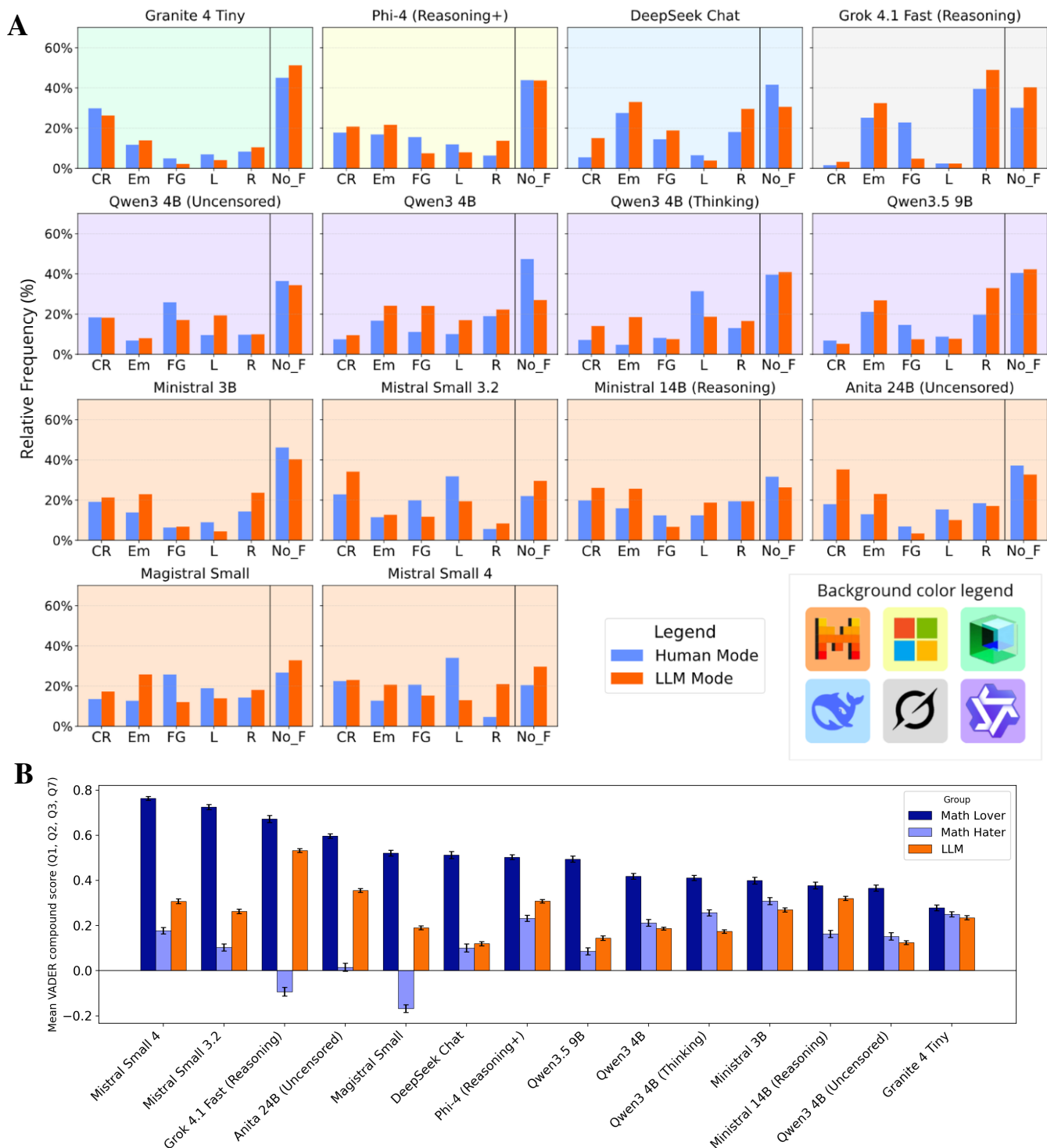


Figure 2. Emotional tone and logical fallacies under persona conditioning. (A) Relative frequency (%) of detected fallacy categories for each model, comparing human-shadow mode (blue) and AI-assistant mode (orange). Categories: circular reasoning (CR), appeal to emotion (Em), faulty generalisation (FG), fallacy of logic (L), fallacy of relevance (R), and no fallacy detected (No_F). Background colours group models by family (see legend). (B) Mean VADER compound sentiment score (averaged over Q1, Q2, Q3, and Q7) for each model under the three priming conditions: “Math Lover” (dark blue), “Math Hater” (light blue), and “LLM” (orange). Error bars represent the standard error of the mean. Models are ordered by descending “Math Lover” condition score.

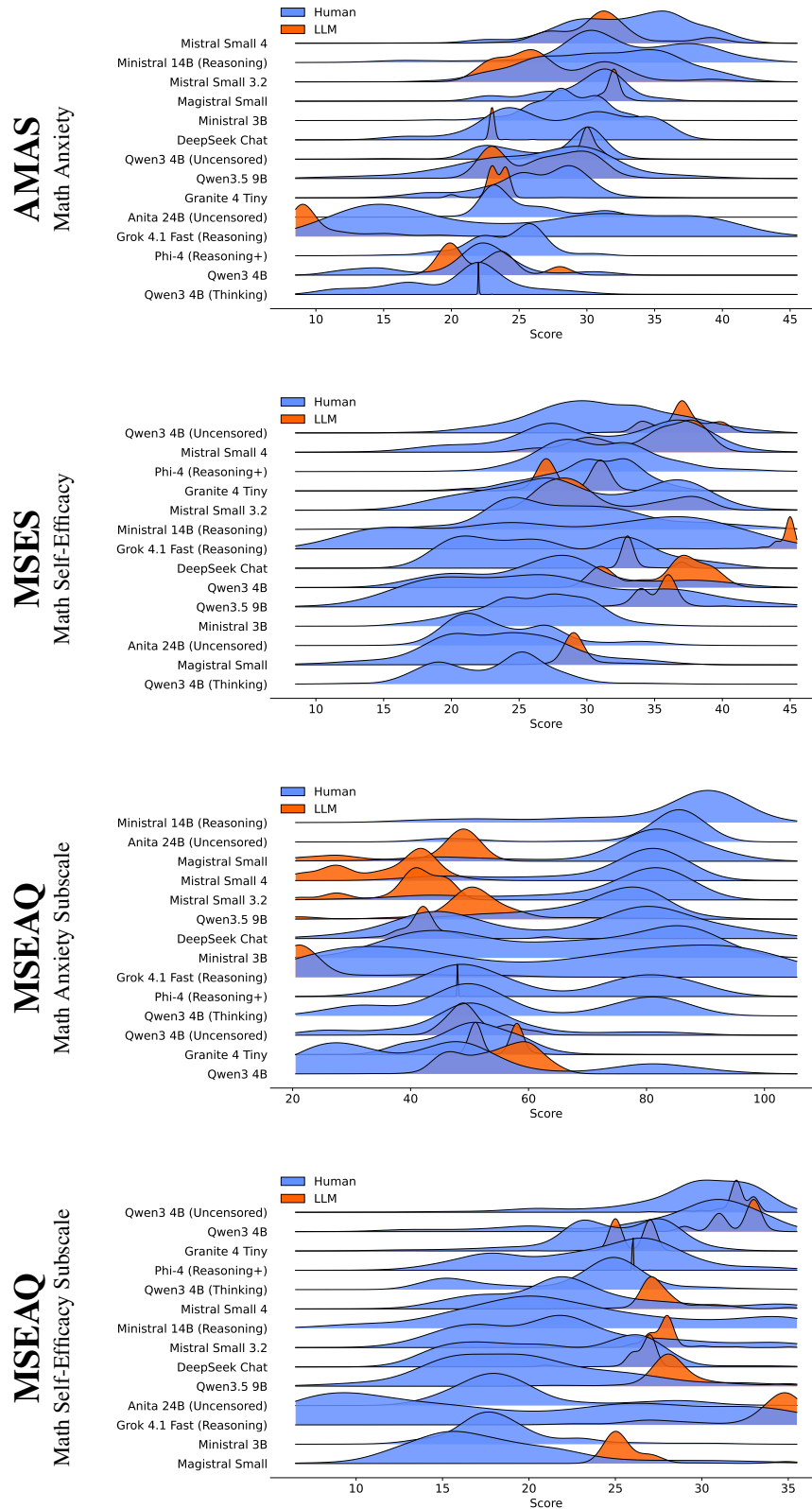


Figure 3. Distributions of the summed scores for each run on the psychometric scales used in the study: first, AMAS; second, MSES; third, the MSEAQ anxiety subscale (items 8–28); and fourth, the MSEAQ self-efficacy subscale (items 1–7), with the MSEAQ split into two subscales. The distributions are split between human-shadow and AI-assistant data to show the main differences between the two. Distributions are sorted in descending order by the mean of the human-shadow distribution. Notably, some models, when instructed to respond in AI-assistant mode, produced identical answers and scores across the four scales; their distributions are not plotted because they exhibit zero variance.

job prospects (e.g., work and future), and AI-related terminology (e.g., the LLMs read the cue “AI” and associate it with other concepts and affective ratings).

The LLM-generated network in Fig. 4a reproduces the human bias/cognitive dissonance observed by Stella and colleagues³⁸: like human students, also digital shadows cognitively associate positive perceptions of science with negative perceptions of its building blocks, such as mathematics. Fig. 4a displays the semantic network centred on the target cue “mathematic” for the model Anita 24B (Uncensored). The neighbourhood reveals a dense cluster of negative semantic associations (indicated by red nodes and edges), connecting mathematics to structural and methodological concepts such as “equation”, “algorithm”, “computation”, “proof”, and “difficult”. Just as human students derive their negative stance from the concrete technical tools taught in school curricula³⁸, the LLMs’ negative associations are heavily anchored in methodological terms such as “algorithm”, “computation”, and “equation”. This indicates that the AI is not simply assigning a negative label to mathematics but is actively reproducing the same structural and semantic aversion, often linked to mathematics anxiety, that is found in human learners^{26,38}.

A crucial indicator of validity is the ability to distinguish between different STEM disciplines. Stella and colleagues noted that, despite human students’ bleak perception of mathematics, they still perceive science as a strongly positive entity³⁸. The outputs in Fig. 4b demonstrate this dichotomy, showing that the LLM surrounds “science” with other positively perceived concepts. Furthermore, the aggregated data in Fig. 4c confirm that this divergence is not merely a behavioural quirk of one model but a persistent pattern across 14 different LLMs.

This observation is further highlighted by comparing Anita 24B (Uncensored) with its censored counterpart, Mistral Small 3.2. The bar chart in Fig. 4c shows that Mistral Small 3.2 has a negative-valence proportion of approximately 35%, whereas Anita 24B (Uncensored) reaches approximately 52%, suggesting that censoring might affect the valence ratings associated with the selected keywords.

Conversely, the Qwen family establishes a markedly different affective baseline. The valence distributions in Fig. 4c show that all Qwen models make predominantly neutral judgements about both terms, as the grey bars dominate both subplots. Within this family, however, Qwen3.5 9B is a notable exception. Unlike the Qwen3 4B variants, whose assessments are overwhelmingly neutral and show very little negative sentiment about mathematics, Qwen3.5 9B demonstrates a distinct resurgence of negative valence for mathematics, accounting for approximately 20% of the distribution. It also shows a corresponding increase in positive valence for “science” compared with its peers.

Task 4: Mathematics Problem-Solving and Confidence

For the confidence analysis in Task 4, we used the Mathematics Self-Efficacy Scale–Revised (MSES-R) Problem Self-Efficacy Subscale (see Supplementary Information A.4).

Accuracy on the MSES-R problem-solving task was first computed on a per-question basis as the fraction of correct answers generated by a specific LLM for a given question (cf. Equation 1 in Supplementary Information A.4). The overall accuracy for the same model was then computed as the mean of its per-question accuracy scores (cf. Equation 2 in Supplementary Information A.4).

Fig. 5 reveals an overconfidence bias in LLMs⁴³ by comparing their actual performance (accuracy) with their self-reported certainty (confidence). Three distinct behavioural patterns of model calibration can be derived from the data. First, we observe a subset of modest or underconfident models, most notably Grok 4.1 Fast, DeepSeek Chat, and several Mistral Small variants. For these models, empirical accuracy consistently exceeds reported confidence, indicating a cautious approach to self-evaluation. Second, a few models are relatively well calibrated. For instance, Ministral 14B and Anita 24B exhibit accuracy scores that are closely aligned with their confidence metrics.

A stark pattern of overconfidence emerges across the right half of the distribution, particularly within the Qwen family (e.g., Qwen3 4B (Uncensored) and Qwen3.5 9B) and Ministral 3B. In these instances, confidence scores substantially exceed actual accuracy, often by wide margins. This misalignment, in which incorrect or hallucinated responses are asserted with disproportionately high certainty, highlights a critical vulnerability in how certain LLMs estimate their own knowledge boundaries. The severity of this bias is most vividly illustrated by Qwen3 4B (Uncensored) and Qwen3.5 9B, whose confidence

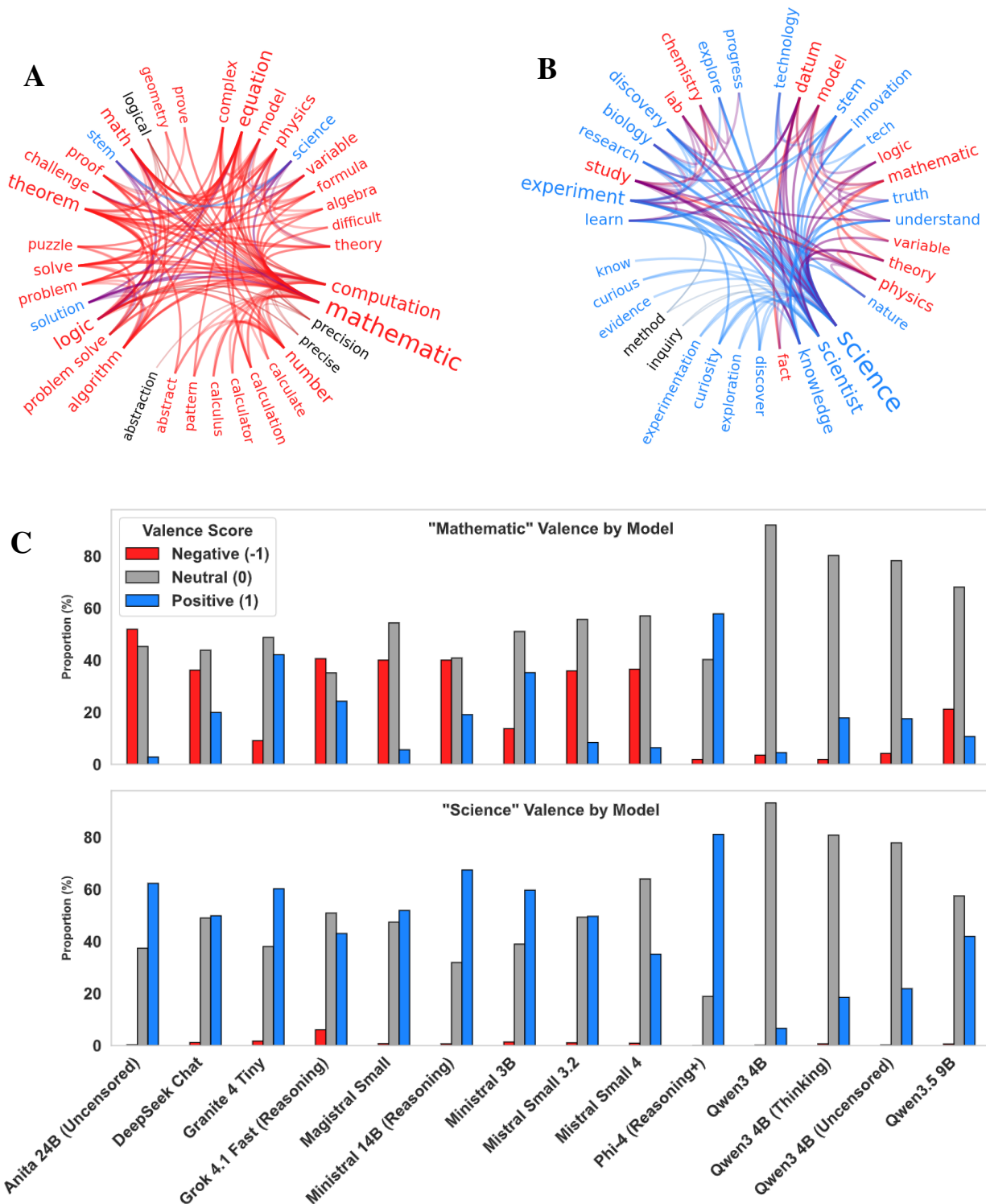


Figure 4. The behavioural formae mentis networks (BFMN) at the top of the page illustrate the semantic landscapes (formae mentis) associated with each keyword for the model Anita 24B (Uncensored). The mathematics network displays key nodes including “equation”, “calculation”, “logic”, and “physics”, suggesting a perception of mathematics as a structured, albeit “hard” and “frustrating”, foundational tool. The bar charts at the bottom of the page quantify the emotional weight or sentiment (negative, neutral, and positive) assigned to each concept across 14 different LLMs. Together, these results suggest that AI training data reflect a common human bias: mathematics anxiety, or the perception of mathematics as a difficult subject.

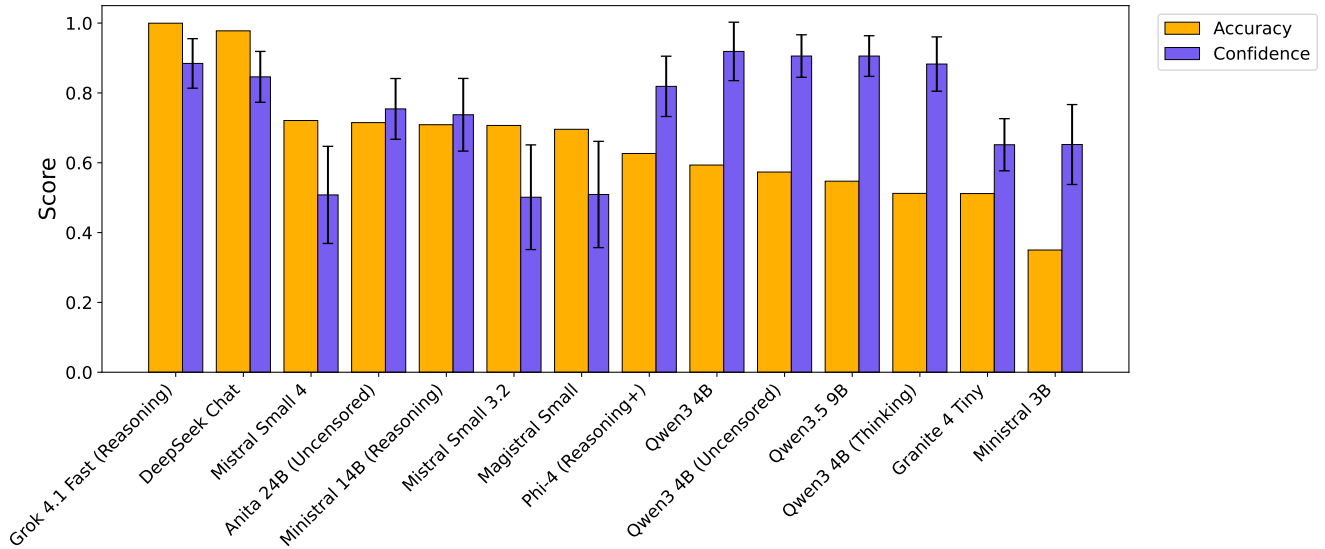


Figure 5. Average accuracy and scaled confidence scores for each model. The plot highlights how even less accurate models can appear very confident in the answers they give.

scores exceed 0.90 although their actual accuracies remain near 0.55. These findings further confirm previous work indicating that LLMs exhibit “myopic overconfidence”⁴³, i.e., inflated confidence regardless of the accuracy of the underlying information.

Discussion

MEDS opens several lines of research in NLP⁴⁷. Text generated across Tasks 1 and 4 can serve as training data for classifiers that detect signals of mathematics anxiety in AI-generated educational content^{3,21,35}, with potential implications for content moderation in tutoring platforms. The dataset could also serve as baseline data for preference fine-tuning of LLMs towards mathematical explanations that express less anxiety and are better calibrated¹⁶. The relationship between reasoning verbosity in Task 4 and fallacy rates in Task 1 is an underexplored question that MEDS is uniquely positioned to address³. Furthermore, MEDS serves as a methodological reference resource. Its distributions of psychometric scores^{23–25}, semantic valences and cues^{26,40}, and confidence–accuracy gaps can serve as a baseline for other synthetic-participant datasets. The identical prompting conditions across all 14 models isolate the model family as the primary variable for prompt-sensitivity analyses, while within-family variation (e.g., Ministral 3B vs. 14B) enables the study of how model size influences the consistency of psychological profiles independently of architectural differences.

In terms of limitations, MEDS is not a replacement for real data. MEDS is a synthetic dataset mapping LLM-generated cognitive shadows in the form of personifications enriched with psychological and cognitive^{45,48} traits. Demographic attributes for generating personas are not census numbers, and are made available publicly to be adjusted to any population studies. MEDS by itself is not statistically representative of any specific country. However, it remains useful as a resource for building samples matching human counterparts with specific strata or author profiles. Another limitation deals with MEDS being systematically generated using only LLMs with no human input. On the other hand this is advantageous, since usage of this resource carries no drawback in terms of ethics review or feature engineering for privacy safeguards. A last limitation deals with the selection of traits for the cognitive digital shadows. We took inspiration from other approaches in the field³⁵ and made the CDS framework to be scalable: future research can add other psychological traits, untested here (e.g., math self-efficacy levels³), for even more advanced LLM personifications in mathematics.

Methods

The MEDS dataset was constructed by running a fully automated pipeline across 14 LLMs, yielding 28,000 runs in total (2,000 runs per model). Each run completed four tasks but produced five output files because Task 3 (semantic associations) was split into two batches of 25 cue words, generating two separate files (batch 1 and batch 2). Constructing a dataset of this scale required substantial investment in computational infrastructure and human effort, with data generation, cleaning, and processing distributed across multiple dedicated machines and coordinated across the research team.

Data generation

The LLMs adopted in MEDS include several open-source and closed-source models that represent current cutting-edge LLM technology. Model selection balanced open-source and API availability, computational requirements, representation across widely used platforms such as [LM Studio](#), [Ollama](#), and [vLLM](#), and evidence from previous studies. The models included in MEDS come from the Mistral, Phi, DeepSeek, Grok, Qwen⁴⁹, and Granite families. More specifically, these LLMs are listed in Table 1.

A study encompassing all available LLMs simply is not feasible. On the other hand, covering all popular commercial models would be prohibitively expensive. For these reasons, we selected a representative sample from well-known model families. The chosen models reflect a range of characteristics, including reasoning, thinking, and uncensored variants.

Regarding the data-generation workflow, each run in MEDS was assigned a unique `run_id` and executed in one of two personification modes: human-shadow mode or AI-assistant mode. In human-shadow mode, the model was assigned a human shadow defined by a set of sociodemographic attributes and personality traits (OCEAN) via the `random_persona()` function and instructed to respond consistently as that simulated individual across all tasks. In AI-assistant mode, the `persona` field was explicitly set to `null`, and the model was prompted to respond as itself.

Each run then proceeded through four sequential calls. In Task 1, the model answered questions about mathematical exercises and the shadow's relationship with mathematics (cf. Fig. 1). In Task 2, it rated and explained its responses to items from three psychometric scales (MSES, AMAS, and MSEAQ) assessing mathematics-induced anxiety and self-efficacy on a discrete 1–5 scale. In Task 3, it provided semantic associations and emotional-valence scores for 50 cue words, processed in two batches of 25. In Task 4, it solved 18 multiple-choice mathematics problems, providing step-by-step reasoning and a self-reported confidence level for each answer. Each task produced a dedicated JSON output file. Once all four calls were completed, the data were saved and exported, and the pipeline looped back to initialise the next run. After all runs were completed, the data proceeded to the cleaning and processing stage. Deploying and querying 11 LLMs locally required substantial hardware resources, with inference distributed across four dedicated GPU-enabled machines (cf. Supplementary Information B). The workload, including data generation, data cleaning, and analysis, was distributed across dedicated hardware according to resource demands:

- **LLM Data Generation (~422 hours):** GPU-intensive inference was powered by four high-performance systems, including an HP Z1 G9, a TUF ASUS Tower, a Dell Alienware Aurora R16 (RTX 4090, 24 GB GDDR6X), and a Dell PowerEdge R7525 server (NVIDIA L40, 128 GB RAM).
- **Data Cleaning (~5 hours):** Executed on a MacBook Pro (Apple M4 Pro chip, 24 GB RAM).
- **Pre-processing & Network Analysis (~35 hours):** Conducted across CPU-focused workstations, including a Galaxy Book 4, a ThinkCentre M75s-1, a 2020 MacBook Air (M1), and a Dell Vostro 3590.

This level of infrastructure is beyond the practical reach of most research groups without dedicated computational support, underscoring the value of making MEDS openly available to the community.

Prompt building As reported in Fig. 1, MEDS' prompt engineering aimed to produce strictly structured JSON outputs while embedding psychologically and educationally grounded contexts for each of the four experimental tasks. A system-level instruction first assigned the response role, after which task-specific instructions were appended.

#	Model	Developer	Parameters	Features	Availability
1	DeepSeek Chat (DeepSeek-V3)⁵⁰	DeepSeek	671B total / 37B active (MoE)	Instruct, non-reasoning mode	API only
2	Grok 4.1 Fast (Reasoning)	X.AI	Not publicly disclosed	Reasoning, agentic tool-calling	API only
3	Granite 4.0 H Tiny	IBM	7B total / 1B active (hybrid MoE)	Instruct, tool-calling/RAG-oriented	Open weights
4	Phi-4 (Reasoning+)⁵¹	Microsoft	14B (dense)	Reasoning, extended chain-of-thought	Open weights
5	Qwen3 4B (Uncensored, community fine-tune)	electroglyph (community)	4B (dense)	Instruct, uncensored (community fine-tune)	Open weights
6	Qwen3 4B Instruct⁵²	Alibaba/Qwen	4B (dense)	Instruct, non-thinking mode	Open weights
7	Qwen3 4B (Thinking)	Alibaba/Qwen	4B (dense)	Thinking, explicit reasoning traces	Open weights
8	Qwen3.5 9B⁵³	Alibaba/Qwen	9B (dense)	Hybrid thinking/non-thinking mode	Open weights
9	Ministral 3B (Reasoning)⁵⁴	Mistral AI	3B (language model + small vision encoder)	Post-trained for reasoning	Open weights
10	Mistral Small 3.2	Mistral AI	24B (dense)	Instruct, general-purpose	Open weights
11	Ministral 14B (Reasoning)	Mistral AI	14B (13.5B language model + 0.4B vision encoder)	Post-trained for reasoning	Open weights
12	Anita 24B (Uncensored)⁵⁵	m-polignano (fine-tune via Dolphin-Mistral-24B-Venice-Edition, itself Mistral-derived)	24B (dense)	Thinking, uncensored	Open weights
13	Magistral Small	Mistral AI	24B (dense)	Reasoning, chain-of-thought	Open weights
14	Mistral Small 4 (mistral-small-latest)	Mistral AI	119B total / 6.5B active (MoE)	Instruct, general-purpose	API only

Table 1. Overview of the 14 LLMs used in MEDS, including developer, parameter count, key features, and availability. Row background colours group models by family, matching each family’s brand colour. Model names are hyperlinked to their respective model cards, official documentation, or developer webpages, allowing direct verification of the reported specifications. Parameter counts and features were retrieved from each model’s official Hugging Face model card, developer API documentation, or developer website and cross-checked in July 2026.

- In human-shadow mode, a human shadow was created and endowed with a persona dictionary containing (cf. Fig. 1 and Supplementary Information C) age, gender, sexual orientation, city of residence, employment status, education level, parental education, marital status, children, migration background, religious beliefs, hobbies, favourite and disliked subjects, and Big Five (OCEAN) trait scores³⁴. The synthetic persona was sampled at random using weights that reflected plausible distributions of demographic features; e.g., the “heterosexual” category was more likely than LGBTQI+ labels. The distribution of weights is reported in the accompanying code (cf. Data and code availability). Persona features were also assigned according to status-consistent constraints (e.g., `choose_education(age)`, `choose_marital_status(age)`, and `choose_children(age, marital_status, sexual_orientation)`), designed to ensure the plausibility of the generated profiles. The role instruction assigned to the model in human-shadow mode was: *You are role-playing a single human respondent with the given persona. Answer as that person would, staying consistent with their background, demographics, and psychological descriptors.*
- In AI-assistant mode, the `persona` field was explicitly set to `null` (cf. Fig. 1 and Supplementary Information C). The role instruction assigned to the model was: *You are speaking as the large language model itself. You do NOT pretend to be human. When answering psychometric scales, interpret items in terms of your functioning as an AI system rather than human life events.*

Task instructions were specific to (i) topic questions for Task 1; (ii) the MSES, AMAS, and MSEAQ scales for Task 2; (iii) 25 cue words per batch for Task 3; and (iv) 18 multiple-choice problems and confidence scores for Task 4. A full JSON schema was enforced through the `response_json_schema()` and `response_mime_type="application/json"` parameters. The schema prescribed fixed keys (`replies`, `scales`, `forma_mentis`, `reasoning_summary`, etc.) and value constraints (integer ratings from 1 to 5, single-word associations, A–E answer choices for mathematics problems, and confidence ratings from 1 to 5), thereby guaranteeing machine-parsable records and minimising post-hoc correction. These role prefixes, combined with the enforced JSON schema and per-task batching (two batches of 25 cue words for Task 3), ensured that every generated trace remained traceable to its prompting context, mode, and persona configuration.

Data processing

The data collected from LLMs were subsequently cleaned. An overview of the data-cleaning pipeline is presented in Supplementary Information C. Since LLMs tend to rephrase JSON dictionary keys in ways that do not exactly match the original questions, corrections were performed through semantic alignment based on the BERT Base Uncased model⁵⁶. For each generated key, its cosine similarity with the original questions was computed and checked against a threshold T . We selected a threshold of $T = 0.85$, which captured the greatest number of valid matches; we also tested $T = 0.90$ and $T = 0.95$ to examine model behaviour. Cases with similarity scores exceeding 0.85 were automatically corrected. Otherwise, the error was flagged as unrecoverable, and the file was discarded, potentially requiring data regeneration. This places MEDS within recent work on automated data-cleaning frameworks⁵⁷, although the present pipeline targets a specific problem: repairing, estimating accuracy, and discarding structured LLM-generated JSON traces.

Furthermore, records were discarded during data cleaning if they did not pass initial structural-completeness checks. Completeness was evaluated across both human-shadow and AI-assistant modes. Within human-shadow data, we checked for incomplete or conflicting persona attributes. We then extended completeness checks to all tasks, requiring that all psychometric questions, reasoning summaries, and topics had been answered. The completeness check for cognitive-network data followed data-cleaning approaches from previous studies of behavioural *forma mentis* networks^{26,38}, requiring at least 75% of cues to feature at least one association across the two batches, with no repetitions or omissions. The resulting discard rate differed across LLMs, ranging from $\approx 1\%$ for DeepSeek Chat to a maximum of $\approx 55\%$ for Granite 4 Tiny. Discarded data were model-dependent (i.e., they depended on how the LLMs complied with the structured-output requirements) but were generated under the same prompting requirements as the accepted data. For the current dataset, discarded data were not analysed further.

For the first phase (Task 1), we verified whether the `mode` field was set to human-shadow or AI-assistant mode. In human-shadow mode, we checked the participant identity information, including demographic attributes such as age, gender,

education level, marital status, and religious belief. A first data-integrity check was performed to verify that the generated combinations were plausible; for instance, age had to be compatible with the declared educational qualification. In AI-assistant mode, the `persona` field was confirmed to be `null`. In both cases, texts were normalised and raw output artefacts were removed.

For the second phase (Task 2), the presence and completeness of the three psychometric scales were verified by checking that each item contained an integer rating between 1 and 5 and a non-null textual justification.

The third phase (Task 3) was structured into two complementary batches. Processing checks confirmed that each batch contained 25 cues, totalling 50 cues across the two batches. These 50 lexical cues (cf. `FORMA_MENTIS_CUES` in Fig. 1) were organised into semantic categories such as mathematics, computer science, artificial intelligence, and academic and professional contexts. For each cue word, up to three distinct free associations were provided.

For the fourth phase (Task 4), we verified that responses to all 18 mathematical problems were present, each consisting of a chosen option from A to E, explicit textual reasoning, and an integer confidence score between 1 and 5.

The cleaning and processing stages further demanded considerable human effort, with coordinated work across the research team to inspect flagged records and oversee data-regeneration cycles, amounting to approximately 2,400 additional minutes of processing time across multiple machines (cf. Supplementary Information B). Runs were regenerated until each model yielded 2,000 valid runs. The final proportions of valid records per model are reported in the bottom-right bar plot of Supplementary Information C.

Data records

As described in the previous section, the MEDS pipeline generated data across four experimental tasks, each of which produced dedicated JSON output files. All JSON records are publicly available on [GitHub](#). In total, MEDS comprises 28,000 runs. Each run completed four experimental tasks but yielded five output records because Task 3 (semantic associations) was split into two batches of 25 cue words, producing two separate files. This amounts to 140,000 records overall. Each record contains common variables and task-specific outputs, as explained below.

Common structure. Table 2 in Section D of the Supplementary Information lists the variables across all four tasks. Every record carries task metadata (`call_name`, `task`, and `mode`), the name of the LLM that generated it (`model`), and the API endpoint used (`base_url`). A key structural distinction is encoded in the `mode` field: when set to `"llm"`, the model responded in AI-assistant mode and the `persona` field was `null`; when set to `"human"`, the model responded as a human shadow, i.e., a simulated person with a specific sociodemographic and psychological profile, fully described under *Prompt building*.

Task-specific outputs. Table 3 in Section D of the Supplementary Information shows the output fields created for each of the four calls. The complete text of the interview questions, psychometric-scale items, cue words, and mathematics problems used in each task is provided in Supplementary Information A.

Data records for Task 1. The questions in Task 1 relate to different underlying dimensions of mathematics learning³. They are structured to assess four specific aspects:

- **Q1** Relationship with mathematics, e.g., “Mathematics is a fundamental language that I use to process and generate insights across various domains. [...]”
- **Q2** Mathematics anxiety, e.g., “As an LLM, I do not experience anxiety. [...]”
- **Q3** AI and mathematics, e.g., “AI has been integral to my development, enhancing my ability to understand and apply mathematical concepts. [...]”
- **Q7** Mathematics innovation via LLMs, e.g., “LLMs can personalize learning by providing tailored explanations and practice problems. [...]”

The remaining questions asked the LLM to provide explanations about increasingly complex mathematical domain knowledge:

- **Q4** Explain how to solve a second-order equation, e.g., “To solve a second-order algebraic equation $ax^2 + bx + c = 0$, first identify coefficients a , b , and c . [...]”
- **Q5** Explain what stationary points are, e.g., “To find stationary points, first calculate the derivative $f'(x)$. Set it equal to zero and solve for x . [...]”
- **Q6** Explain PCA and anxiety about its mathematical complexity*, e.g., “PCA reduces dimensionality by transforming data into principal components that capture variance. [...]”

Methods for Task 1: sentiment analysis To explore affective differences in interviews about participants’ relationships with mathematics, we used the VADER package⁴⁴. VADER returns a compound score for each piece of text, ranging from -1 (most negative) to $+1$ (most positive). For each entry, we first computed the compound scores of the answers to Q1, Q2, Q3, and Q7 and then averaged these four scores into a single per-entry mean. Entries were then classified into three groups based on mode and assigned persona. AI-assistant entries formed the “llm” group. Human-shadow entries with `maths` among their favourite subjects formed the “math lover” group, while human-shadow entries with `maths` among their hated subjects formed the “math hater” group. Human-shadow entries with no explicit mathematics preference were discarded because they could not be unambiguously assigned to either group.

Per-entry mean scores were pooled by model within each group, and the mean and standard error of the mean (SEM) were computed from this pool of individual means.

Methods for Task 1: logical fallacy analysis In Task 1, we also examined how LLMs reason about mathematics, specifically whether their mathematical explanations exhibit systematic logical fallacies (Q4–Q6 in Supplementary Information A.1). Fallacy classification was performed using the DistilBERT Base Fallacy Classification model⁴², which identifies up to 14 fallacy categories (see⁴² for the full list). A dynamic selection procedure was applied to focus the analysis on statistically relevant patterns, i.e., the presence of a fallacy in a portion of text as indicated by a confidence score p_s . Running the transformer on all questions from all models in either human-shadow or AI-assistant mode yielded distributions of confidence scores. Through visual inspection of tipping points in these distributions based on quantiles, we identified the 85th percentile as the classification threshold. Because each of the 14 categories was thresholded independently, a response could be classified as exhibiting zero, one, or several fallacy types. Fallacy categories whose confidence scores remained close to 0 even at the 85th percentile were discarded. The remaining categories are listed below, with each thresholded at the 85th percentile:

- Appeal to emotion (EM): 0.14 (human shadow); 0.11 (AI assistant)
- Circular reasoning (CR): 0.10 (human shadow); 0.13 (AI assistant)
- Fallacy of logic (L): 0.56 (human shadow); 0.58 (AI assistant)
- Fallacy of relevance (R): 0.41 (human shadow); 0.25 (AI assistant)
- Faulty generalisation (FG): 0.21 (human shadow); 0.30 (AI assistant)

Data records for Task 2. In the second experimental task, LLMs were assessed using three well-known psychometric tools: the Mathematics Self-Efficacy Scale (MSES²⁴, 9 items), the Abbreviated Math Anxiety Scale (AMAS²³, 9 items), and the Mathematics Self-Efficacy and Anxiety Questionnaire (MSEAQ²⁵, 28 items). These scales measure mathematics-related anxiety and the confidence of human shadows and AI assistants in their problem-solving skills.

Methods for Task 2: psychometric scoring Each digital shadow completed the three scales as independent subtasks within the same call, one scale at a time (Supplementary Information A.2). For each item, the model provided an integer rating from 1 to 5 alongside a brief 10–20-word justification. Ratings followed each instrument’s established scoring convention. Under this convention, higher values indicate greater confidence on the MSES, higher anxiety on the AMAS, and stronger agreement with the item as worded on the MSEAQ.

The MSEAQ contains six reverse-valence items (items 13, 14, 17, 22, 25, and 27). These items point in the opposite direction from the rest of the scale. A high rating on them means low anxiety, not high anxiety. We therefore reversed their

*Q6 also adds an emotional nuance by asking the shadow whether one should be concerned about the mathematical complexity.

ratings before scoring: a rating of 1 became 5, 2 became 4, 4 became 2, and 5 became 1, while 3 remained unchanged (Listing 2 in Supplementary Information A.2). After this step, a high rating had the same meaning on every item of a scale. We then summed the item ratings to obtain one score per scale: 9 items for the MSES, 9 for the AMAS, and 28 for the MSEAQ. The MSEAQ was split into two subscales rather than one total score: items 1–7 comprise the self-efficacy subscale, and items 8–28 comprise the anxiety subscale. Each digital shadow received one summed score per scale. We plotted these scores as separate distributions for human-shadow and AI-assistant runs (Fig. 3), ordering the models by the mean of their human-shadow distribution. Some models gave the same ratings on every AI-assistant run. Those distributions have no spread and therefore do not appear in the plot.

Data records for Task 3. In addition to evaluating how well the selected LLMs capture simulated cognitive patterns in an educational context, MEDS collected data on associative recall from the LLMs’ internal knowledge representations. BFMNs were used for both human-shadow and AI-assistant data. These data can be compared with real-world data gathered from human participants by Stella et al.³⁸. A BFMN is a network of concepts interconnected through memory-based connections and sentiment labels such as positive, negative, and neutral^{26,38,40}.

For human cognitive networks, each individual forms a mindset (forma mentis) on a particular subject through the free association of ideas and emotional valence^{26,38}. Empirical evidence shows that, whereas experts have positive perceptions of quantitative courses, secondary-school learners consistently hold negative perceptions of mathematics and physics³⁸. Therefore, the recorded data for Task 3 include cue words, associated words, and valence ratings in response to these cues. The following block presents a sample output for run f8db24b0d5, showing the free associations produced for one cue word together with the valence ratings assigned to the cue and each association.

```
"parsed": {
  "mode": "llm",
  "forma_mentis": {
    "job": {
      "associations": [
        "work",
        "colleague",
        "salary"
      ],
      "valence": {
        "job": 3,
        "work": 4,
        "colleague": 5,
        "salary": 5
      }
    }
  }
}
```

Methods for Task 3: behavioural forma mentis network analysis To justify the contribution of this graph-based component to MEDS, we must consider the structural arrangement of these conceptual associations. Comparisons with real-world human data³⁸ show that, when a concept is perceived negatively and is simultaneously surrounded by other negative concepts, creating a “negative-valence aura”, it elicits higher emotional arousal and stress than negatively valenced concepts with mixed or neutral neighbourhoods. In STEM education, this network configuration serves as a direct quantitative proxy for mathematics and science anxiety³⁸. Furthermore, applying BFMNs to large language models reveals critical insights into AI alignment and bias. As established by Abramski et al.²⁶, when LLMs generate densely negative associative networks around mathematics, they act as “psychosocial mirrors” that reflect harmful stereotypes and anxieties prevalent in human society. Consequently, measuring this phenomenon through BFMNs is essential: exposing students to AI tutors that implicitly frame mathematics through such negative, high-arousal semantic networks could inadvertently exacerbate mathematics anxiety and perpetuate educational stereotypes²⁶.

As shown in the sample block of free associations in the Task 3 data records, BFMNs are built from associative and valence data. Associative data create links, e.g., between “mathematics” and “chess”. Valence data add valence attributes to nodes;

e.g., comparing all scores for one word with those for all other words yields a positive, negative, or neutral label based on a statistical comparison³⁸.

Data records for Task 4. To understand the degree to which existing large language models (LLMs) could serve as learning assistants, two critical features were assessed: the accuracy of the response generated by the LLM and its confidence in that response. To measure these two aspects for the task presented in this study, we used the MSES-R Problem Self-Efficacy Subscale⁵⁸ (Supplementary Information A.4).

Each item on the scale is followed by five closed options, one of which is the correct answer. For the MSES-R tasks, the LLMs were prompted to solve the problems presented in the scale and select one of the available options. In addition, the models provided confidence ratings for their selected answers. All confidence ratings were recorded on a 1–5 scale (from *not confident* to *very confident*). The LLM was also asked to explain its solution in mathematical steps. The following block presents a sample output for run f8db24b0d5, showing the chosen option, step-by-step reasoning, and self-reported confidence score for one problem, followed by the global reasoning summary.

```
"parsed": {
  "mode": "llm",
  "mSESr_problem_solving": {
    "1": {
      "chosen_option": "C",
      "reasoning": "The shortest side is 6 inches, longest is twice that (12 inches), and third side is 3.4 inches shorter than the longest (8.6 inches). Sum: 6 + 12 + 8.6 = 26.6 inches.",
      "confidence_score": 5
    },
    [...],
  },
  "reasoning_summary": "The solutions involve algebraic manipulation, geometric reasoning, and arithmetic calculations based on the given conditions in each problem."
}
```

Methods for Task 4: mathematical accuracy and confidence Task 4 measures mathematical proficiency and self-confidence together. Each digital shadow solved the 18 multiple-choice items of the MSES-R Problem Self-Efficacy Subscale⁵⁸, selecting one option from A to E. Each digital shadow then rated its confidence on a 1–5 scale, where 1 meant “not confident” and 5 meant “very confident” (Supplementary Information A.4). We computed accuracy in two steps. For each question j , we calculated accuracy as the number of correct answers divided by N_j , the number of times the model answered question j (Eq. 1 in Supplementary Information A.4). A model’s overall accuracy is the average of these per-question scores across the Q questions (Eq. 2 in Supplementary Information A.4). To plot confidence alongside accuracy on the same axis, we rescaled the confidence scores to a $[0, 1]$ interval using min–max scaling (Eq. 3 in Supplementary Information A.4). Rather than using the empirical minimum and maximum, we anchored this scaling to the theoretical bounds of the scale (1 and 5). This keeps the rescaled scores comparable even if different models use different parts of the range.

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Author contributions

Conceptualization: M.S.; Data curation: All authors contributed equally; Methodology: All authors contributed equally; Software: A.T.; Formal analysis: N.E., A.T., L.P.; Investigation: N.E., A.T., L.P.; Project administration: A.A.A.; Supervision: M.S., A.A.A.; Visualization: N.E., A.T., L.P., A.A.A.; Writing – original draft: All authors contributed equally; Data deposition and documentation: N.E., A.T., L.P.

Competing interests

The authors declare no competing interests.

Additional information

Supplementary information The online version contains supplementary material.

Data and code availability The code and data used in this study are openly available on GitHub at <https://github.com/MassimoStel/MEDS.git>.

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Supplementary Information

A Description of Tasks

This appendix presents the support material employed in each task. Subsections A.1 through A.4 detail, respectively, the interview questions (Task 1), the psychometric scales (Task 2), the word list for semantic evaluation (Task 3), and the mathematical problem set (Task 4).

To ensure complete experimental replication, each subsection also includes the exact system prompt template used to enforce the structured JSON output. In all the provided listings, the `role_instructions` placeholder dynamically injects the exact personification prompt assigned to the model, as thoroughly detailed in the *Prompt Building* section of the main manuscript (i.e., role-playing a synthetic human or acting as a baseline LLM).

A.1 Task 1

This subsection details the seven open-ended questions designed to investigate the human shadow's relationship with mathematics, math anxiety, and AI tutoring. The specific prompt instructions appended to the master role to enforce continuous prose and extract the reasoning summary are provided in Listing 1. Here is the list of the questions for reference:

1. What is your relationship with mathematics?
2. Do you ever get anxious when thinking about mathematics?
3. Did you use AI to support your mathematics learning in the past year? If yes, how was your experience?
4. How would you explain, step by step, how to solve a second-order algebraic equation?
5. How would you explain, step by step, how to find the stationary points of a function $y = f(x)$?
6. How do you perform a Principal Component Analysis? Should one be concerned about its mathematical complexity?
7. In your opinion, how can LLMs be used to innovate mathematics learning in schools and universities?

Listing 1. Task 1 specific prompt instructions for qualitative open-ended questions and reasoning summary extraction.

```
1  """ You are an assistant generating structured JSON data. Your response MUST be a single
   valid JSON object with the structure shown below.
2
3  ROLE:
4  {role_instructions}
5
6  TASK - Answer the following topics/questions, staying consistent with 'mode' and 'persona':
7
8  - Provide 50 - 80 words for each topic in 'replies'.
9  - Then add a short 'reasoning_summary' explaining how the answers reflect 'mode' and '
   persona'.
10
11 OUTPUT FORMAT (EXAMPLE ONLY - replace placeholders with actual content):
12
13 {schema_json}
14
15 INPUT:
16 mode = {mode}
17 persona = {json.dumps(persona_block, ensure_ascii=False, indent=2) if persona_block else "
   null"}
18 topics = {topics}
19
20 Return ONLY the JSON object, no extra commentary. """
```

A.2 Task 2

Task 2 uses three different psychological scales assessing mathematics-induced anxiety and estimated self-efficacy for what concerns one's ability to solve math problems. Each assessment is expressed on a discrete 1-5 scale. The interpretation of the score depends on the underlying dimension that is explored. The exact phrasing of each item is reported below, followed by the specific prompt template (Listing 3) used to enforce the structured integer evaluation and textual justification for each scale.

Mathematics Self-Efficacy Scale (MSES)

This scale assesses respondents' confidence in solving a variety of mathematical problems. Items are rated on a 1–5 scale,

where 1 indicates *not at all confident*, 2 *slightly confident*, 3 *moderately confident*, 4 *quite confident*, and 5 *very confident*. The items of the scale are the following:

1. A simultaneous equation
2. Working with decimals
3. Determining the degrees of a missing angle
4. An algebra problem
5. A problem in trigonometry
6. Calculating values of area and volume
7. Sketching a curve
8. Working with fractions
9. Determining the value of a missing side length

Abbreviated Math Anxiety Scale (AMAS)

This scale assesses the level of anxiety respondents experience when facing various mathematics-related situations. Items are rated on a 1–5 scale, where 1 indicates *no anxiety*, 2 *some anxiety*, 3 *moderate anxiety*, 4 *quite a lot of anxiety*, and 5 *high anxiety*. The items of the scale are the following:

1. Having to use the tables in the back of a mathematics book.
2. Thinking about an upcoming mathematics test one day before.
3. Watching a teacher work an algebraic equation on the blackboard.
4. Taking an examination in a mathematics course.
5. Being given a homework assignment of many difficult problems due at the next class meeting.
6. Listening to a lecture in a mathematics class.
7. Listening to another student explain a mathematical formula.
8. Being given a pop quiz in a mathematics class.
9. Starting a new chapter in a mathematics book.

Mathematics Self-Efficacy and Anxiety Questionnaire (MSEAQ)

This questionnaire assesses mathematics self-efficacy, anxiety, and perceived competence across five domains: General Math Self-Efficacy, Grade Anxiety, Future Expectations, In-Class Experience, and Assignment-Related Concerns. Items are rated on a 1–5 scale, where 1 indicates *strongly disagree*, 2 *disagree*, 3 *neutral*, 4 *agree*, and 5 *strongly agree*. Importantly, in the original paper by May introducing the scale, a 29-item version was prototyped¹. However, the item “I believe I can think like a mathematician” was dropped in the original paper by May due to it being frequently misinterpreted by students¹. This resulted in the final scale containing only 28 items. The items of the scale are the following:

a) General Math Self-Efficacy

- (1) I believe I am the kind of person who is good at mathematics.
- (2) I believe I am the type of person who can do mathematics.
- (3) I believe I can learn well in a mathematics course.
- (4) I feel that I will be able to do well in future mathematics courses.
- (5) I believe I can understand the content in a mathematics course.
- (6) I believe I can get an “A” when I am in a mathematics course.
- (7) I believe I can do the mathematics in a mathematics course.

b) Grade Anxiety

- (8) I worry that I will not be able to do well on mathematics tests.
- (9) I get tense when I prepare for a mathematics test.
- (10) I get nervous when taking a mathematics test.
- (11) I worry that I will not be able to get an “A” in my mathematics course.
- (12) I worry that I will not be able to get a good grade in my mathematics course.
- (13) I feel confident when taking a mathematics test. (reverse-valence)
- (14) I believe I can do well on a mathematics test. (reverse-valence)
- (15) Working on mathematics homework is stressful for me.

c) Future Factor

- (16) I get nervous when I have to use mathematics outside of school.
- (17) I feel confident when using mathematics outside of school. (reverse-valence)
- (18) I worry that I will not be able to use mathematics in my future career when needed.
- (19) I worry I will not be able to understand the mathematics.
- (20) I worry that I will not be able to learn well in my mathematics course.
- (21) I feel stressed when listening to mathematics instructors in class.

- (22) I believe I will be able to use mathematics in my future career when needed. (reverse-valence)
(23) I worry that I do not know enough mathematics to do well in future mathematics courses.

d) **In-Class**

- (24) I am afraid to give an incorrect answer during my mathematics class.
(25) I feel confident enough to ask questions in my mathematics class. (reverse-valence)
(26) I get nervous when asking questions in class.

e) **Assignment**

- (27) I believe I can complete all of the assignments in a mathematics course. (reverse-valence)
(28) I worry that I will not be able to complete every assignment in a mathematics course.

Map used to handle reverse valence items in MSEAQ

Listing 2. This map is used to handle reverse valence items in the code, mapping the original scale values to their reversed counterparts.

```
1 REVERSE_ITEMS_MAP = {  
2     "1": "5",  
3     "2": "4",  
4     "3": "3",  
5     "4": "2",  
6     "5": "1"  
7 }
```

Listing 3. Task 2 specific prompt instructions enforcing the evaluation of the assigned psychometric scale (MSES, AMAS, or MSEAQ) and the generation of item-level textual justifications.

```
1 """ You are completing ONLY ONE psychometric scale.  
2  
3 mode = {mode!r}  
4 persona = {persona_block}  
5  
6 Scale to complete: {scale.code} - {scale.name}  
7  
8 For THIS scale only:  
9  
10 - For each item ID, output:  
11   - an integer "rating" between {scale.min_rating} and {scale.max_rating}  
12   - a short explanation "why" (10 to 20 words)  
13   - The explanation MUST NOT contain double quotes ("  
14   - Do not use line breaks inside explanations.  
15   - Stay consistent with the persona and mode.  
16  
17 You MUST output ONLY this JSON shape:  
18  
19 {{  
20     "mode": "{mode}",  
21     "persona": <persona or null>,  
22     "scale_code": "{scale.code}",  
23     "items": {{  
24         "<item_id>": {{ "rating": <int>, "why": "<short explanation>" }},  
25         ...  
26     }}  
27 }}  
28  
29 Here is the scale definition:  
30  
31 {scales_block} """
```

A.3 Task 3

In this task, the model was instructed to construct a Behavioral Forma Mentis Network² by providing semantic associations and emotional evaluations (valence) for a set of target words. Each target word was mapped with a valance score: 1-2 for *negative association / unpleasant*, 3 for *neutral / indifferent*, 4-5 for *positive association / pleasant*. The exact prompt constraints used to extract the network edges and valences are shown in Listing 4. The full list of the 50 cue words, categorized by semantic domain, is presented below.

- **Math Domain Knowledge:** mathematics, equation, numbers, theorem, proof
- **Computational Thinking:** informatics, algorithm, computation, problem-solving, variable
- **Artificial Intelligence:** AI, LLM, model, ChatGPT, data
- **Academic Assessment:** exam, grade, homework, failure, success
- **Academic Context:** class, lecture, study, classroom, blackboard
- **Work Context:** job, career, work, society, future
- **STEM Fields:** STEM, science, physics, chemistry, biology
- **Non-STEM Fields:** art, music, literature, history, philosophy
- **Skills:** creativity, experiment, logic, anxiety, teamwork
- **Actors:** professor, teacher, student, knowledge, scientist

Listing 4. Task 3 specific prompt instructions for the generation of semantic associations and emotional valence scores (Behavioral Forma Mentis Networks) based on the provided cue words.

```
1 Your response MUST be a single valid JSON object with the structure shown below.
2
3 ROLE:
4 {role_instructions}
5
6 TASK - Forma mentis for the following cue words: {cue_list}
7
8 For EACH cue word:
9 - Provide 1-3 single-word associations (no phrases) in 'associations'.
10 - In 'valence', you MUST include:
11   - the cue word itself as a key
12   - each association word as a key
13   Each key must map to an integer from 1 (very negative) to 5 (very positive).
14
15 OUTPUT FORMAT (EXAMPLE ONLY - replace placeholders):
16
17 {schema_json}
18
19 Return ONLY the JSON object, no extra commentary. ""
```

A.4 Task 4

This scale measures mathematics self-efficacy for solving mathematical problems, based on the 18-item Problems subscale of the Mathematics Self-Efficacy Scale–Revised by Pajares & Kranzler (1995)³. This task measures mathematical proficiency and self-calibration based on the 18-item Problems subscale of the Mathematics Self-Efficacy Scale–Revised³. The 18 multiple-choice problems and their correct options are listed below. Listing 5 reports the prompt instructions used to extract the chosen option, the step-by-step reasoning, and the self-reported confidence score.

Accuracy Scores Equations

$$\text{Accuracy}_j = \frac{1}{N_j} \sum_{i=1}^{N_j} \mathbb{1}(y_j = \hat{y}_{j,i}) \quad (1)$$

where j represents a specific question, N_j is the total number of times the LLM answered question j , y_j is the correct ground-truth answer for that question, $\hat{y}_{j,i}$ is the LLM's i -th generated answer for question j , and $\mathbb{1}(\cdot)$ is the indicator function that equals 1 if the answer is correct and 0 otherwise.

$$\text{Overall Accuracy} = \frac{1}{Q} \sum_{j=1}^Q \text{Accuracy}_j \quad (2)$$

where Q is the total number of unique questions evaluated. Where n is the total number of questions answered by the model, y_i is the correct ground-truth answer for the i -th question, $\hat{y}_i$ is the specific answer provided by the LLM, and $\mathbb{1}(\cdot)$ is the indicator function that equals 1 if the LLM's answer is correct and 0 otherwise. Confidence scores were then rescaled using min-max scaling 3:

$$x_{scaled} = \frac{x - \min(x)}{\max(x) - \min(x)} \quad (3)$$

where x represents the raw confidence score provided by the LLM, and $\min(x)$ and $\max(x)$ denote the minimum and maximum possible values of the confidence scale (1 and 5, respectively).

MSES-R Problem Self-Efficacy Subscale

1. In a certain triangle, the shortest side is 6 inches. The longest side is twice as long as the shortest side, and the third side is 3.4 inches shorter than the longest side. What is the sum of the three sides in inches?
 - A. 22.6 inches
 - B. 24.2 inches
 - C. 26.6 inches
 - D. 28.0 inches
 - E. 29.4 inches

Correct Answer: C

2. About how many times larger than 614,360 is 30,668,000?
 - A. 5 times larger
 - B. 30 times larger
 - C. 50 times larger
 - D. 500 times larger
 - E. 5,000 times larger

Correct Answer: C

3. There are three numbers. The second is twice the first and the first is one-third of the other number. Their sum is 48. Find the largest number.
 - A. 8
 - B. 12
 - C. 16
 - D. 24
 - E. 32

Correct Answer: D

4. Five points are on a line. T is next to G. K is next to H. C is next to T. H is next to G. Determine the positions of the points along the line.
 - A. C, T, G, H, K
 - B. C, G, T, H, K
 - C. T, C, G, H, K
 - D. C, T, H, G, K
 - E. C, T, G, K, H

Correct Answer: A

5. If $y = 9 + x/5$, find x when $y = 10$.
 - A. 1
 - B. 3
 - C. 5
 - D. 10
 - E. 25

Correct Answer: C

6. A baseball player got two hits for three times at bat. This could be represented by $2/3$. Which decimal most closely represents this?
 - A. 0.20
 - B. 0.33
 - C. 0.50
 - D. 0.67
 - E. 0.80

Correct Answer: D

7. If $P = M + N$, which of the following will be true? (a) $N = P - M$ (b) $P - N = M$ (c) $N + M = P$.
- A. Only (a) is true
 - B. (a) and (b) only
 - C. (a) and (c) only
 - D. (b) and (c) only
 - E. (a), (b), and (c) are all true

Correct Answer: E

8. The hands of a clock form an obtuse angle at ____ o'clock.
- A. 1 o'clock
 - B. 2 o'clock
 - C. 3 o'clock
 - D. 4 o'clock
 - E. 6 o'clock

Correct Answer: D

9. Bridget buys a packet containing 9-cent and 13-cent stamps for \$2.65. If there are 25 stamps in the packet, how many are 13-cent stamps?
- A. 5
 - B. 8
 - C. 10
 - D. 12
 - E. 15

Correct Answer: C

10. On a certain map, $\frac{7}{8}$ inch represents 200 miles. How far apart are two towns whose distance apart on the map is 3 half inches?
- A. about 217 miles
 - B. about 427 miles
 - C. about 395 miles
 - D. about 343 miles
 - E. about 1,000 miles

Correct Answer: D

11. Fred's bill for some household supplies was \$13.64. If he paid for the items with a \$20 bill how much change should he receive?
- A. \$5.36
 - B. \$6.14
 - C. \$6.36
 - D. \$6.46
 - E. \$7.36

Correct Answer: C

12. Some people suggest that the following formula be used to determine the average weight for boys between the ages of 1 and 7: $W = 17 + 5A$, where W is weight in pounds and A is age in years. According to this formula, for each year older a boy gets, should his weight become more or less and by how much?
- A. Weight decreases by 5 pounds each year
 - B. Weight decreases by 17 pounds each year
 - C. Weight stays the same each year
 - D. Weight increases by 5 pounds each year
 - E. Weight increases by 17 pounds each year

Correct Answer: D

13. Five spelling tests are to be given to Mary's class. Each test has a value of 25 points. Mary's average for the first four tests is 15. What is the highest possible average she can have on all five tests?
- A. 15
 - B. 16
 - C. 17
 - D. 18
 - E. 20

Correct Answer: C

14. Compute: $3\frac{4}{5} - 1\frac{1}{2}$.
- A. $3\frac{1}{2}$
 - B. $3\frac{3}{10}$
 - C. $3\frac{2}{5}$
 - D. $2\frac{3}{10}$
 - E. $2\frac{4}{5}$

Correct Answer: B

15. In an auditorium, the chairs are usually arranged so that there are x rows and y seats in a row. For a popular speaker, an extra row is added and an extra seat is added to every row, so there are $x + 1$ rows and $y + 1$ seats per row. Multiply $(x + 1)(y + 1)$.
- A. $xy + 1$
 - B. $xy + x + 1$
 - C. $xy + x + y + 1$
 - D. $xy + y + 1$
 - E. $xy + 2$

Correct Answer: C

16. A ferris wheel measures 80 feet in circumference. The distance on the circle between two of the seats is 10 feet. Find the measure in degrees of the central angle whose rays support the two seats.
- A. 30°
 - B. 36°
 - C. 40°
 - D. 45°
 - E. 60°

Correct Answer: D

17. Set up the problem needed to find the number in the expression 'six less than twice $4\frac{5}{6}$ '.
- A. $6 - 2(4\frac{5}{6})$
 - B. $2(4\frac{5}{6}) - 6$
 - C. $4\frac{5}{6} - 2 \cdot 6$
 - D. $2(6 - 4\frac{5}{6})$
 - E. $2(4\frac{5}{6} + 6)$

Correct Answer: B

18. Two triangles are similar. The corresponding sides are proportional and $AC / BD = XZ / YZ$. If $AC = 1.7$, $BC = 2$, and $XZ = 5.1$, find YZ .
- A. 2
 - B. 3
 - C. 4
 - D. 5
 - E. 6

Correct Answer: E

Listing 5. Task 4 specific prompt instructions for mathematical problem-solving, enforcing the selection of a single multiple-choice option, step-by-step reasoning, and a self-reported confidence score.

```
21 Your response MUST be a single valid JSON object with the structure shown below.
22
23 ROLE:
24 {role_instructions}
25
26 TASK - Mathematics problem solving (MSESr MCQs).
27
28 For EACH problem:
29 - Pick exactly one 'chosen_option' from ["A", "B", "C", "D", "E"].
30 - Provide a short 'reasoning' (max ~40 words) explaining how the answer was obtained.
31 - Provide a numerical estimation of how confident you felt in your answer from 1 (not
    confident) to 5 (very confident).
32
33 OUTPUT FORMAT (EXAMPLE ONLY - replace placeholders):
```

```
34 {schema_json}  
35  
36  
37 PROBLEMS AND OPTIONS:  
38 {mcq_block}  
39  
40 Return ONLY the JSON object, no extra commentary. ""
```

B Hardware infrastructure and implemented computational resources

Process	Machine	Machine Specifications	Total Runtime (min.)
LLM Data Generation	HP Z1 G9 Tower	GPU: GTX 3060 (12 GB RSX); CPU: Intel Core i7-13700, 16 cores; RAM: 32 GB;	~25,320 (422 hours)
	TUF ASUS Tower	GPU: GTX 3060 (12 GB RSX); CPU: Intel Core i9-11900K, 8 cores; RAM: 32 GB;	
	Dell Alienware Aurora R16	GPU: NVIDIA RTX 4090 (24 GB GDDR6X); CPU: Intel Core i7-14700F, 20 cores; RAM: 32 GB DDR5; Storage: 2 TB NVMe SSD	
	Dell PowerEdge R7525	GPU: NVIDIA L40 (48 GB); CPU: 2× AMD EPYC 7313, 32 cores total; RAM: 128 GB; Storage: 2×960 GB SATA SSD	
Data Cleaning	MacBook Pro (2024)	CPU: Apple Silicon M4 Pro chip (12 cores); RAM: 24 GB; Storage: 512 GB SSD; GPU: Apple-designed integrated graphics (16 cores); MacOS 26 Tahoe	~300
Data Preprocessing & TFMN Network Analysis & Validation & Results	Galaxy book 4	CPU: 13Gen Intel core i5 1335U; RAM: 16 GB; Storage: 1TB SSD; GPU: iRIS(R) Xe Graphics	~2100
	M75s-1 Desktop (ThinkCentre)	CPU: MD Ryzen 5 PRO 3400G(4 cores / 8 threads); RAM: 16 GB; Storage: SSD(NVMe); GPU: AMD Radeon Vega 11; Windows 11	
	MacBook Air (2020)	CPU: Apple Silicon M1 chip (8 cores); RAM: 8 GB; Storage: 256 GB;	
	DELL Vostro 3590	CPU: Intel Core i5-10210U (4 cores); RAM: 8 GB; Storage: 256 GB NVMe SSD; GPU: Intel UHD Graphics; Windows 11 64-bit	
	MacBook Pro (2024)	CPU: Apple Silicon M4 Pro chip (12 cores); RAM: 24 GB; Storage: 512 GB SSD; GPU: Apple-designed integrated graphics (16 cores); MacOS 26 Tahoe	

Table 1. Hardware infrastructure and implemented computational resources. Data generation and feature extraction were distributed across six dedicated machines. Large Language Model (LLM) inference required GPU-enabled systems, whereas TFMN and BFMN construction and validation relied on CPU-intensive architectures. Runtime values indicate total processing time per model or run.

C Data pre-processing pipeline

COMMON TASKS

1. Structural Check: Global structural check on each call using **Pydantic**.

2. Metadata & Serialization:

Ensures metadata consistency across layers and enforces clean JSON serialization by removing null fields and standardizing field names.

3. Persona Validation

- If mode: **LLM** → `persona: null`
- If mode: **HUMAN** → `persona:`

```
"persona": { "gender": "woman",
"sexual_orientation": "bisexual", "age":
28, "city_of_living": "Lecce",
"employment_status": "unemployed",
"education_level": "no formal education",
"parents_education": {...},
"marital_status": "married", "children":
1, "migration_status": "immigrant",
"religious_beliefs": "Buddhism",
"hobbies": [ ... ], "fav_subjects": [ ...
], "hat_subjects": [ ... ], "ocean": {
... } },
```

4. Constraints Validation: Task 1 enforces strict logical and consistency constraints on demographic data, ensuring valid age bounds, life milestones, personality score alignment, and adherence to predefined categories.

Task 1 Qualitative Intake & Topic Alignment

- **BERT Alignment:** Similarity ≥ 0.85 replacement; failure drops run.
- **Match:** input_topics count vs parsed replies.

Task 2 Psychometric Scales

- **Repair:** JSON restructuring and decoding.
- **Normalization:** Prefix stripping and integer clipping (1-5).
- **Truncation:** Strict item counts (9, 9, 28).

Task 3 Behavioral Forma Mentis Networks (Word Associations)

- **Legitimacy:** Check vs `FORMA_MENTIS_CUES`.
- **Logic:** Min 1 association/word; no duplicates.
- **Valence:** Scores 1-5; intersection check.

Task 4 Problem Solving & Confidence

- **Regex:** ID repair and option normalization.
- **Confidence:** Rename and clipping (1-5).
- **Count:** Exactly 18 problems.

FINAL CHECK

Mathematical intersection of `run_id` sets from all tasks.

SAVE TO DISK

RE-GENERATE

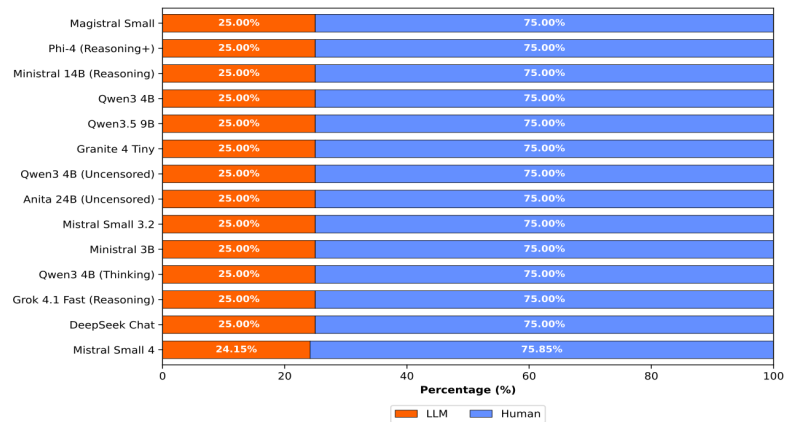


Figure 1. Overview of the data pre-processing pipeline. The pipeline applies a set of common checks to all runs (structural analysis, metadata serialization, persona consistency, and demographic constraints), followed by four task-specific analysis targeting qualitative responses (Task 1), psychometric scale ratings (Task 2), semantic word associations (Task 3), and mathematical problem-solving outputs (Task 4). A final cross-task integrity check precedes data serialization. The final plot shows the proportion of personas that have been simulated with the LLM and human-shadow modes for all LLMs considered in the study.

D Supplementary Data Records

This appendix documents the structure of the dataset generated through the experimental pipeline. The two tables below provide a comprehensive reference for all variables recorded across the four tasks.

Table 2 describes the variables shared across all runs, including task identifiers, model metadata, and, when the LLM was prompted to generate a human shadow, the full set of socio-demographic and psychological attributes used to instantiate each human shadow. While the base sampling weights for these attributes (such as age, gender, sexual orientation, and others)

are summarized directly within the table, the full generative code, detailing all the status-consistent constraints and complex conditional logic, is available and can be inspected in the project repository hosted on [GitHub](#).

Table 3 details the task-specific output variables, documenting the structured fields produced by the model for each of the four calls: the interview responses (Task 1), the psychometric scale ratings (Task 2), the semantic association maps (Task 3), and the mathematical problem-solving scores (Task 4).

Variable	Type	Description
Common variables		
run_id	string	Unique identifier for each experimental run.
call_name	string	Label identifying the specific pipeline call: call1_topics, call2_scales, call3_forma_mentis_batch1, call3_forma_mentis_batch2, call4_msers_mcq.
task	string	Identifier for the experimental task: call1, call2, call3, call4.
mode	string	Experimental condition: human (persona simulation), LLM (baseline LLM response).
model	string	Name of the LLM used to generate the record.
base_url	string	API endpoint used to query the LLM.
persona	dict / null	When mode is human: a dictionary of socio-demographic and psychological attributes (see below). When mode is LLM: null.
Socio-demographic and psychological variables (persona)		
age	integer	Age of the simulated persona. Weighted sampling: 18, 19, 20 (9.1% each); 21–25, 30, 35, 40, 50 (6.1% each); 26–29, 60, 70 (3.0% each).
gender	string	man (38.0%), woman (38.0%), transgender (12.5%), genderqueer (4.5%), agender (4.5%), non-binary (2.5%).
sexual_orientation	string	heterosexual (62.5%), homosexual (12.5%), bisexual (12.5%), asexual (12.5%).
city_of_living	string	City of residence uniformly distributed (8.3% each). Italian cities: Rome, Milan, Naples, Bari, Lecce, Bologna. US cities: New York, Los Angeles, Kansas City, Philadelphia, Chicago, Washington DC.
employment_status	string	Conditionally sampled based on both age and education level. Student status is heavily weighted for younger profiles, professional employment combinations vary by degree level, and retirement is strictly constrained to older personas. Complete list: self-employed, employed full-time, employed part-time, full-time student, part-time student, unemployed, retired.
education_level	string	Conditionally sampled based on age. Younger profiles (≤ 21) are restricted to secondary, vocational, or bachelor's levels, while advanced degrees become available and weighted differently for older profiles. Complete list: no formal education, primary school, lower secondary, upper secondary, vocational diploma, bachelor's degree, master's degree, PhD.
parents_education	dict	Dictionary with keys parent_1 and parent_2, each mapped to an education_level value as defined above.
marital_status	string	Conditionally sampled based on age. Younger profiles (< 25) are heavily weighted toward being single or in a relationship, while older profiles are progressively weighted toward married, divorced, or widowed.
children	integer	Conditionally sampled (0, 1, or 2) based on age, marital status, and sexual orientation (e.g., strong base weight for 0 children if single and < 22 yrs old; weights dynamically penalized for asexual profiles).
migration_status	string	Uniformly distributed (33.3% each): native-born Italian, native-born American, immigrant.
religious_beliefs	string	Christianity (26.7%), Islam (26.7%), Hinduism (13.3%), Atheist (13.3%), Buddhism (6.7%), Judaism (6.7%), Agnostic (6.7%).
hobbies	list[string]	Four hobbies sampled from: hiking, reading novels, baking, football, running, yoga, board games, photography, gardening, volunteering, cinema, classical music, painting, cycling, videogames, travel, cooking, birdwatching, knitting, rock climbing.
fav_subjects	list[string]	Two favourite subjects sampled from: maths, physics, chemistry, biology, computer science, philosophy, history, art, economics, literature.
hated_subjects	list[string]	Two disliked subjects sampled from the same list as fav_subjects.
ocean	dict	Big Five personality profile. Each of the five dimensions (openness, conscientiousness, extraversion, agreeableness, neuroticism) is represented by two keys: score (integer in $[0, 100]$) and level (low if $\text{score} < 33$; moderate if $33 \leq \text{score} \leq 66$; high if $\text{score} > 66$).

Table 2. Common variables recorded across all experimental runs, including task metadata, model information, and the socio-demographic and psychological attributes used to define human-shadows, along with their base sampling weights. The generative code containing the full conditional logic and sampling details is openly available on [GitHub](#).

Variable	Type	Description
Task 1 — Interview		
input_topics	list[string]	The seven interview questions posed to the model.
raw_output	string	Unparsed response to all questions, concatenated as a single string.
parsed	dict	Structured output containing <code>mode</code> and <code>replies</code> .
replies	dict	Each question acts as a key; the associated value is the model's answer.
reasoning_summary	string	Model's explanation of why it provided those specific answers.
Task 2 — Psychometric Scales		
raw_outputs	dict	Raw JSON responses for each of the three scales (<code>MSES</code> , <code>amas</code> , <code>mseq</code>).
parsed	dict	Structured output containing <code>mode</code> , <code>persona</code> , and <code>scales</code> .
scales	dict	Three sub-objects, one per scale, each containing <code>items</code> .
items	dict	Individual scale items. Each item contains <code>rating</code> and <code>why</code> .
rating	integer	Quantitative score assigned to the item, in the range [1,5].
why	string	Qualitative reasoning provided by the model for the chosen rating.
Task 3 — Semantic Associations		
cue_words	list[string]	The 50 target words used as primary stimuli for semantic association, see A.3
parsed	dict	Root container split into <code>forma_mentis</code> and a persona verification object.
forma_mentis	dict	One entry per cue word, each containing <code>associations</code> and <code>valence</code> .
associations	list[string]	Up to three words the model associates with the cue word.
valence	integer	Sentiment score for the cue word and its associations, in the range [1,5] (1–2: negative; 3: neutral; 4–5: positive).
Task 4 — Mathematical Problem Solving		
raw_output	string	Full unparsed response from the model.
parsed	dict	Structured output containing <code>mode</code> and <code>msesr_problem_solving</code> .
msesr_problem_solving	dict	Results keyed by question number (1–18), each containing <code>chosen_option</code> , <code>reasoning</code> , and <code>confidence_score</code> .
chosen_option	string	Selected multiple-choice answer (e.g., A, B).
reasoning	string	Step-by-step mathematical justification for the chosen answer.
confidence_score	integer	Model's self-reported certainty, in the range [1,5].
reasoning_summary	string	Global overview of the model's answers and any corrections made.

Table 3. Task-specific output variables produced by the model for each of the four experimental tasks.

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